THE EASE OF LIVING

As hunger for internet-based solutions grew, so did the urgency for a structured approach to address the connectivity problem. That's where BharatNet stepped in, signalling a fundamental shift to bridge India's rural-urban digital divide. The project aims to provide affordable high-speed broadband internet across 268,000-odd gram panchayats, covering over 665,000 villages. Though launched in 2011-12, the real push came under the Digital India initiative after Prime Minister Narendra Modi came to power in 2014. The first phase capitalised on existing optical fibre networks of BSNL, RailTel and Power Grid, covering 100,000 gram panchayats by December 2017. It was around this time that the strategy changed as the government set out to expedite the coverage to 150,000 gram panchayats slotted under Phase 2. It includes laying fresh optical fibre cables, using radio and satellite technologies and setting up 700,000-plus public Wi-Fi hotspots—all with collaborative efforts with state governments and private entities. The total funding stands at Rs 42,068 crore under the first two phases.

With internet access, rural communities can now participate in digital commerce and access financial services, quality education and medical expertise

Engagement occurs through a revenue-sharing model. Village-level entrepreneurs (VLEs) run service centres next to Wi-Fi hotspots, creating community internet points and keeping daily operations smooth. By involving locals, the project seeks better accountability and encourages infrastructure upkeep. By December 2024, BharatNet achieved remarkable milestones, connecting over 214,283 gram panchayats with 690,000 km of optical fibre and establishing over 104,574 Wi-Fi hotspots. The median mobile broadband speed stood at 95.67 Mbps in October 2024. BharatNet, in comparison, provides a minimum speed of 100 Mbps.

With internet access, rural communities can now participate in digital commerce, access financial services and explore entrepreneurial opportunities. Students and patients now have access to quality education and medical expertise from urban centres. To fix shortcomings, the focus has shifted to a design change at a cost of Rs 1.39 lakh crore under Phase 3—which reaffirms the government's commitment to leverage broadband connectivity to uplift communities. ■

HOW IT TRANSFORMED MY LIFE

"Students are far more excited about school now"

Deep in the tribal belt of South Gujarat's Tapi district, internet was a rarity as recently as 2022. Those who had a smartphone could be seen staring at it restlessly as mobile connectivity was unstable and slow. It was then that the gram panchayat of Sakarda village in Uchchhal taluka got broadband connectivity under BharatNet. One of the beneficiaries was Sakarda Primary School—and its 165 students and seven teachers across Grades 1–8.

"Now, all classes have a smart board on which we receive elaborate study material to help teachers with complex subjects," says Vijay Gamit, the school principal who also teaches Grades 3–5. "Students are far more excited about school now as we show them online videos on laptops to supplement textbook learning." Children also get to attend online yoga classes and watch videos for cultural performances. "They love the audio-visual aspect," says Gamit. ■

VIJAY GAMIT, 54

Elementary school principal, Tapi, Gujarat



–Jumana Shah